

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Federal Reserve officials** cut interest rates for a third straight meeting but signaled they may be done for now amid unusual divisions over the path forward. **A1**
- ◆ **Wall Street cheered** the central bank's rate cut, lifting the S&P 500 0.7% to within striking distance of a record. The Dow and Nasdaq rose 1% and 0.3%, respectively. **A2**
- ◆ **Powell said that** Fed staffers believe that federal data could be overestimating job creation by up to 60,000 positions a month. **A2**
- ◆ **Blue Origin and SpaceX** are competing to take the data-center boom into space, developing satellites to provide orbital artificial intelligence computing platforms. **B1**
- ◆ **Oracle's revenue** and operating income for the most recent financial quarter fell slightly short of analysts' expectations and the company raised its spending forecast. **B3**
- ◆ **Coca-Cola said** Chief Executive James Quincey will step down from his role in March and be replaced by Henrique Braun, the company's operating chief. **B1**
- ◆ **YouTube TV is** introducing a slate of genre-specific channel packages in early 2026, offering consumers more flexibility to pick the content they are willing to pay for. **B1**
- ◆ **Tony Dokoupil was** named anchor of "CBS Evening News," taking over the program as CBS News undergoes a transformation. **B3**
- ◆ **Trump said that** the ownership of CNN should change no matter who succeeds in acquiring Warner Bros. Discovery. **B11**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The Trump administration** has handed European leaders documents laying out its vision for the rebuilding of Ukraine and the return of Russia to the global economy. **A1**
- ◆ **European leaders** were considering whether to lend Ukraine around half of the \$200 billion of frozen Russian assets held in the Continent over the next two years. **A8**
- ◆ **The U.S. seized an** oil tanker off the coast of Venezuela, Trump said, marking an escalation in his pressure campaign against Maduro. **A6**
- ◆ **The daughter of Nobel** laureate María Corina Machado collected the Peace Prize for her mother, who was delayed in arriving in Oslo after her clandestine exit from Venezuela. **A1, A6**
- ◆ **The U.S. plans to** screen foreign visitors' social-media history for entry, including citizens of countries such as the U.K. and France that are covered by a visa-waiver program. **A3**
- ◆ **Australia imposed its** ban on social media for children under 16, dividing opinion on whether it will make anyone safer and is even enforceable. **A7**
- ◆ **A judge ordered an** end to the deployment of the National Guard in Los Angeles, dismissing the administration's claim that troops were needed to maintain law and order. **A3**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** jettisoned a plan to honor the abolition of slavery, women's suffrage and the civil-rights movements on quarters. **A4**
- ◆ **More Republicans** in Congress are breaking with party leaders and seeking to extend expiring Affordable Care Act subsidies. **A4**

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Fed Cuts Rates, Signals a Pause

Trim is third straight as officials split over whether to target inflation or jobs

By NICK TIMIRAOS

Federal Reserve officials cut interest rates for a third straight meeting but signaled they may be done for now amid unusual divisions over the path forward.

The decision Wednesday to reduce the benchmark federal-funds rate by a quarter point—to between 3.5% and 3.75%, a three-year low—is

aimed at protecting against a sharper-than-anticipated slowdown in hiring.

The Fed voted 9-3, the first time in six years that three officials cast dissents. Two officials thought the reduction wasn't warranted, while another favored a larger, half-point cut.

With progress on inflation stalled, officials had indicated in the run-up to this week's decision that further reductions could require evidence of labor-market deterioration.

"We're well positioned to wait and see how the economy evolves from here," Fed Chair Jerome Powell said at a news

conference.

On Wednesday, their painstakingly calibrated postmeeting statement signaled a higher bar to additional cuts by echoing a similar pivot after cutting rates one year ago.

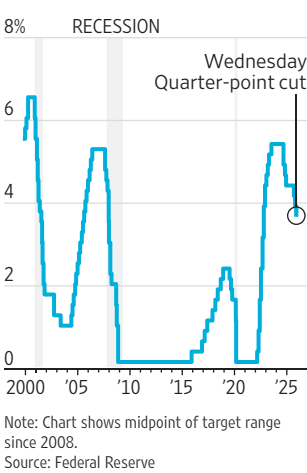
Still, Powell defended the decision to cut now rather than wait until the Fed's next meeting in late January, when it will have significantly more data that had been delayed due to this fall's government shutdown.

He suggested that after ad-

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◆ **Federal Reserve's stance** cheers market..... **A2**

Federal-funds rate target



Europe, U.S. Clash On Future Of Ukraine After War

Trump wants access to frozen Russian assets and to bring Moscow in from cold

The Trump administration in recent weeks has handed its European counterparts a series of documents, each a single page, laying out its vision for the reconstruction of Ukraine and the return of Russia to the global economy.

By Joe Parkinson,
Benoît Faucon
and Drew Hinshaw

The proposals have sparked an intense battle at the negotiating table between the U.S. and its traditional allies in Europe. The outcome stands to profoundly alter the economic map of the Continent.

The U.S. blueprint has been spelled out in appendices to current peace proposals that aren't public but were described to The Wall Street Journal by U.S. and European officials. The documents detail plans for U.S. financial firms and other businesses to tap roughly \$200 billion of frozen Russian assets for projects in Ukraine—including a massive new data center to be powered by a nuclear plant currently occupied by Russian troops.

Another appendix offers the U.S.'s broad vision for bringing Russia's economy in from the cold, with U.S. companies investing in strategic sectors from rare-earth extraction to drilling for oil in the Arctic, and helping to restore Russian energy flows to Western Europe and the rest of the world.

Some European officials who have seen the documents said they weren't sure whether to take some of the U.S. proposals seriously. One official compared them to President Trump's vision of building a Riviera-style development in Gaza. Another, referring to the proposed U.S.-Russia energy deals, said it was an economic version of the 1945 conference where World War II victors divvied up Europe.

A White House official said Trump and his team were working to strike a deal to end the war. In a call on Wednesday, Trump discussed the peace process with French

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◆ **U.S. seizes an oil tanker** off Venezuela..... **A6**

◆ **EU eyes Russian assets** for loans to Kyiv..... **A8**

Opposition Leader Fled Venezuela For Norway by Land, Sea and Air

Wearing a wig and a disguise, María Corina Machado began her escape from Venezuela on Monday afternoon.

By José de Córdoba,
Vera Bergengruen
and Alex Leary

The Venezuelan opposition leader was trying to get to Norway by Wednesday in time to receive the Nobel Peace Prize she won for challenging the country's authoritarian leader, Nicolás Maduro.

After finally arriving in

Oslo, Machado stood on the balcony of the city's central Grand Hotel early Thursday and waved to supporters. They yelled "¡valiente!"—Spanish for brave—and sang the Venezuelan national anthem.

Before she could make the trip, Machado had to get from the Caracas suburb where she has been in hiding for a year to a coastal fishing village, where a skiff awaited her.

Over the course of 10 nerve-racking hours, Machado and two people helping her escape hit 10 military check-

points, avoiding capture each time, before she reached the coast by midnight, a person close to the operation said.

She rested for a few hours, the person said, before the next leg of her journey: a perilous trip across the open Caribbean Sea to Curaçao. She and her two companions set out on a wooden fishing skiff at 5 a.m., the person said, with strong winds and choppy seas slowing them down.

She had almost completed an escape that had been in the works for about two

months and was carried out by a Venezuelan network that has helped other people to flee the country, the person said. The group made an important call before they set out to the U.S. military, warning them of the vessel's occupants to avoid the kind of airstrike that has hit more than 20 other similar vessels in the past three months, killing more than 80 people.

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Massive Takeovers Return, Powered By Debt

By MATT WIRZ
AND BEN GLICKMAN

The megadeal is back and so is Wall Street's immense appetite for debt.

Paramount's hostile bid for Warner Bros. Discovery this week, the leveraged buyout of gaming company Electronic Arts earlier this year and other recent debt-laden transactions have all been possible thanks to an increase in lending by banks and even some private-credit funds.

Big-ticket mergers and acquisitions, or those valued at \$10 billion or more, hit a record dollar amount this year, according to Dealogic. Much of the price tag on those deals gets paid for with debt.

Debt-heavy deals mean large paydays for shareholders but also more risks for bond investors when credit markets are showing signs of overexu-

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL

The popular airport lounge where everybody knows your name. **A11**



SPORTS

He's the best young pitcher in baseball—and he could be on the trading block. **A16**

One Town's Plan to Address Financial Crisis: Nude Calendars

Residents of Lakeview, Ore., stripped down to raise money for snow plowing

By ROSHAN FERNANDEZ

When a small town in Oregon couldn't afford to properly clear the snow from its streets, residents took the only natural step: They stripped.

A group of mostly middle-aged and elderly men and women volunteered to pose

nude for a calendar to raise money for Lakeview. The photos feature a 72-year-old man picking berries (Mr. September) and a 77-year-old woman reclining in a metal bathtub (cover).

"If you take your clothes off, your face looks different,"

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Kyiv Innovates With Daring Drone Operation

Plan to destroy Russian bombers took meticulous planning—and luck

KYIV, Ukraine—One of the most audacious covert operations in modern warfare almost fell apart when a Russian truck driver placed a panicked call to the Ukrainian who had hired him.

By James Marson,
Jane Lytvynenko
and Serhii Bosak

The roof of the pre-fabricated cabin on the back of his truck had slid off, the driver said, revealing an unexpected and illicit cargo. "This is some kind of bulls—," the driver told the transport manager, Artem Tymofeyev. "There are drones under the roof."

"What the f—?" replied Tymofeyev, feigning ignorance.

In fact, the drones were part of a clandestine operation planned by the Security

Service of Ukraine, or SBU, targeting Russia's massive bomber fleet. Tymofeyev, a 37-year-old Ukrainian based in Russia, was the main on-the-ground coordinator.

Back in Kyiv, the operation's planners were sweating, according to people involved in it. What if the trucker couldn't get the roof back on? What if Russian security services were watching him? What if he told his wife, and she told friends?

They came up with a just-about-plausible explanation to relay to the driver: The cabins were hunting lodges with drones used for tracking animals across large areas.

The driver soon texted Tymofeyev with a photo of the roof placed back atop the cabin and a single word: "Closed." Operation Spiderweb was back on.

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